4.0. FEMINISM AND ITS STRANDS/VARIETIES

4.1. Introduction

Feminism refers to the movements and ideologies aimed at defining, establishing and defending equal political, economic and social rights for women & men. It includes seeking to establish equal opportunities for women and men in education and employment among other spheres of human endeavor. The feminist movement gave rise to a large body of theory that attempts to explain gender inequalities and suggests how the inequalities can be done away with. From feminist literature, it is evidently clear that there is no single feminist theory, rather, there are varieties of feminist theories and hence, several feminisms. Although there are various strands of feminism, **their central thesis is that women have been confined to motherhood, domesticity (home life) and an economic dependence on men through gendered socialization in which biological make up is exploited as though it was social** (Fulcher & Scott, 2011). Consequently, many feminists particularly those of Marxist and radical leanings see mainstream feminist theory as *malestream* theory anchored on patriarchy that imply male power over females and whose language remains largely masculine.

While **most strands of feminism seem to have a bone to pick with patriarchy, the difference between them is their individual approaches that no doubt target patriarchy and its support structures and interestingly and fiercely so fight one another**. Hence, in addition to attacking patriarchy and capitalism, **they also seem to fiercely look down**

upon one another regarding their ability to augment women liberation. A striking feature of all the varieties of feminism is that **they seem to present a negative critic, sometimes justified of all the others-each take a moral high ground**. It is this moral high ground position taken by each strand of feminism **that makes them unable to reach consensus and tame patriarchy, their aim**. Like Babylonians building the tower of Babel therefore, the possibility of achieving their aim is not just remote but highly impossible **without a change of tact and organization**. To get a clear understanding of the foregoing, it is important to appraise the arguments in each strand of feminism and finally make a conclusion.

4.2. Marxist Feminism

To begin with, Marxist feminists believe that the subordination of women by men and therefore apparent invisibility in matters of property and development are rooted in the capitalist system of economic production and the privatization of property and means of production (Fulcher & Scott, 2011; Haralambos, Holborn & Heald, 2008). As such Marxist feminists emphasize the interaction between patriarchy and capitalism and hence argue that the subordination of women in the household benefits the capitalist employer by providing free domestic labor. The wife's domestic labor is seen by Marxist feminist as a windfall/bonus to capitalism in two ways. On the one hand, it meets the home needs of the male worker, enabling him to work long hours in the capitalist economy, while the

nurturing and nursing work of the wife helps to bring up the next generation of workers.

Based on the foregoing, Marxist feminists see the disadvantaged position of women as a consequence of privatization of property and its skewed ownership which bestows power on men while denying women of the same (Haralambos, Holborn & Heald, 2008). Indeed, many studies attribute gender stratification to economic roles and see certain roles as more sex-linked than others (Fulcher & Scott, 2011; Ganihar & Begum, 2007; Kottak, 1991). Due to their arguments, Marxist feminists have been criticized by socialist feminists on the ground that they are gender-blind in their analysis-causes of gender inequalities are invisible in structural Marxist analysis of class inequality (Connelly, MacDonald, Li & Parpart, 1996). In general, Marxist feminists prefer a revolution to the capitalist society and have communist society installes so that inequalities are done away. Communist society is classless (Turner, 1991; Abraham, 1982).

4.3. Radical Feminism

Radical feminism is a perspective within feminism that calls for a radical re-ordering of society in which male supremacy is eliminated in all social and economic contexts, while recognizing that women's experiences are also affected by other social divisions such as in race, class, and sexual orientation. Radical feminism believes that patriarchy is not only associated

with capitalism but found in all known societies. As such, radical feminists rejected the liberal ideas of legislative reforms for direct political opposition aimed at challenging the basis of the social and political order (Haralambos, Holborn & Heald, 2008; Fulcher & Scott, 2011). **The central concern of radical feminism is women rights as opposed to gender equality** and as such blame the exploitation and discrimination of women on men. Even as they are united in their fight for women rights, there are however, just like other feminisms, variance among radical feminists about "both the origin of women's oppression and the possible solution to it" (Haralambos, Holborn & Heald, 2008: 101**). True to their name, radical feminists call for radical changes and believe that a revolution is the only solution to liberate women from oppression.**

In addition, **the radical feminists regard men as the real oppressors of women and hence reject any assistance from men since they see men as the problem rather than the solution**. One strand of radical feminism, **the separatists** believe in organizing for their liberation separate from men while another one**, the female supremacist**, see women as not equal to men, but actually superior. They advocate for the abolition of patriarchy and its replacement by matriarchy.

4.4. Socialist Feminism

Socialist feminism borrows from both Marxist and radical feminist frameworks and the general argument of this **school is that women subordination to men has been due to the capitalism-patriarchy nexus**

(link/connection), which oppresses and exploits women. According to Ritzer (2004) in the patriarchal capitalist society, women are defined as the property of men. In analyzing the two, this framework combines them, hence capitalist patriarchy and sets out to describe and explain all forms of social oppression and domination using knowledge of class and gender as a base (Mwenzwa, 2011). It is from this base that oppression and domination of women by men, starting at the family unit and running through to the global hierarchization of nations is explained. Jordan and Weedon (1995) have captured the foregoing thus,

> Capitalism has an interest in maintaining gender identity relations
>
> which guarantee a **low paid expendable (replaceable) female workforce in manufacturing and service industry**, a largely feminized and low-
>
> paid public sector and an underpaid workforce to care for the
>
> children, elderly and disabled in their own homes.
>
> (Ibid, 1995:185)

As a departure from the traditions of other strands, socialist feminism is concerned not only with women oppression by men, **but also how women participate in the systems that oppress other women**. This way, the theory helps to confront the prejudices and oppression practices within the community of women itself while remaining committed to the analysis of

what Ritzer (2004) calls material and social arrangements in society, capitalist patriarchy. In this commitment, the **socialist feminists use the strategy of the process of rediscovery in which they attempt to involve the oppressed groups so as to act together in pursuit of collective emancipation (liberation/freedom)**.

Peet and Hartwick (1999) say that, this theory has significantly involved the re-theorizing of the importance of women's work**, by regarding the needs for childbearing and raising as being as important as material needs.** In this approach, the theory questions the **under valuation of domestic work, most of which requires female physical labor** (Haralambos, Holborn & Heald, 2008; Mwenzwa, 2011; Fulcher & Scott, 2011). By emphasizing on the importance of both domestic and off-farm work, the theory demystifies and tries to de-stereotype the society with regard to gender roles, seeing each individual as important in development.

4.5. Liberal Feminism

On its part, liberal feminism takes a **moderate view and hence posses less challenge to the existing values including the system of patriarchy**. It **therefore proposes gradual change in the political, economic and social systems of western society**. It is rooted in the liberal philosophical tradition of the 16th and 17th centuries whose focus was equality and liberty (Connelley, MacDonald, Li & Parpart, 1996). Liberal feminists **see women subordination as resulting from social norms and not biological make up**. For this reason, inequality that is skewed against women cannot be

justified rationally, but with appeal to gender-based biases. While acknowledging that women **are at a lower social, economic and political pedestal as compared to men, they unlike radical and Marxist feminists root for legal reforms.**

The concern for liberal feminism is **equality of opportunity for men and women and equal treatment before the law**. **This requires a minimum threshold of non-discriminatory laws and policies** (Fulcher & Scott, 2011). The liberal conception of equality is that all people are capable of rational thinking and that equality has to be justified on rational terms (Connelley, MacDonald, Li & Parpart, 1996; Haralambos, Holborn & Heald, 2008). Given their **soft stance regarding women liberation**, they have ruthlessly been criticized by radical feminists and accused **on encouraging women to accept unequal society and its competitive character** (Giddens, Duneier & Appelbaum, 2006; Eisenstein, 1978). On this ground, liberal feminism is seen by other feminisms as **being incapable of upsetting the status quo and consequently incapable of liberating women from the yoke of patriarchy and capitalism.**

4.6. Black Feminism

Black feminism on its part was born out of the **dissatisfaction with other strands of feminism in that they were seen as treating women as a homogeneous group** with identical needs and experiences. Black feminists

argue that the other feminism are **basically based on the experiences and discourse of white middle class women** and therefore **failing to tackle the problems that face black women adequately** (Eisenstein, 1978). They contend that while **middle class white women** are discriminated on the basis of **gender and class**, black women **face triple discrimination** by virtue of their **gender, race and social class.** The foregoing is captured by Haralambos, Holborn & Heald (2008) thus,

> Black women suffer from disadvantage because they are black,
>
> because they are women and because they are a working class, but
>
> their problems are more than the sum [total] of these parts
>
> Haralambos, Holborn & Heald (2008, 104)

It is the intercourse/interaction of race, gender and social status as far as black feminism is concerned that reinforces and multiplies the other inequalities to the great disadvantage of black women. Given, black feminism is therefore a discourse to understand the tri-nexus between race, gender and class and how **this intersection shape lives and restrict the self-actualization of black women**. It may however need to be pointed that, whereas black feminism criticized other strands on the ground of theoretical racism, the emergence of black feminism itself is based on racist ideology-the pot calling the kettle black. This is due to the fact that,

although black feminists pride themselves in fighting sexism and racism, their organization and discourse seems racist in nature. Indeed, as captured by Eisenstein (1978) racism was a major reason why black feminists were unwilling to work with white feminists.

4.7. Other Feminisms

Other strands of feminism are no different from the previously discussed as they are all hell-bent on criticizing one another, although primarily concerned with women liberation, albeit racist and other sectarian standpoints. For example, **African feminism** takes a racist stand by advocating for the rights of African women, while accusing other feminisms of being racists and hence ignoring the plight of African women. It tries to justify its stand by claiming that its aim is to bring out the differences between women who were colonized and those who colonized. Akin-Aina (2011) has characterized African feminism as a movement which is an,

> ongoing process of self-definition and re-definition; a broad-based
> membership; a resistance to the distortions and misrepresentations
> by Western global feminism; a 'feminism of negotiation'; as well
> as efforts to reconcile power dynamics on the continent, nationally
> and within the movement

(Akin-Aina, 2011: 66)

African feminism is therefore against the western universalizing and homogenizing of women, which is characteristic of western feminist discourse. African feminist aver/claim that African women had experiences that are significantly varied from those of western women and therefore a single feminist discourse cannot adequately capture the experiences in the continent.

4.8. Conclusion

Based on the foregoing expose, it is clear that feminism remains disjointed and as such working together is not one of the foreseen aspects of its present strands. While feminists are not united against oppressive behavior of the capitalist society and patriarchy, they seem to be in fierce battle with one another. Unity as such is elusive as captured by Hooks (2000) thus,

> But women could not band together to further feminism without
> confronting our sexist thinking. Sisterhood could not be powerful
> as long as women were competitively at war with one another.

(Hooks, 2000: 3)

In conclusion, there are socio-cultural imperatives that must be put in place so that gender insensitive practices that have been institutionalized

through cultural umbrella of reality can acquire a paradigm shift from their negative effects towards rational thinking about men and women in society. To bring change in the social, political economic and educational fields among others, like Ganihar and Begurn (2007) attest, there is need for substantive change of attitude comprised of contracts, relations and values about men and women in society. Without such substantive transformation, women are likely to remain, like Hooks (1984) points out, at the margins of society and fail, like the Babylonians to *erect their Babel*. This is more so given that most feminist discourse is anti-male and hence patriarchy-disengaging in nature. Pointedly, by viewing men as bad and women good, many strands of feminism seem to ignore the fact that there are many women who take active part in systems that oppress women and at the same time there are respected men feminists.